

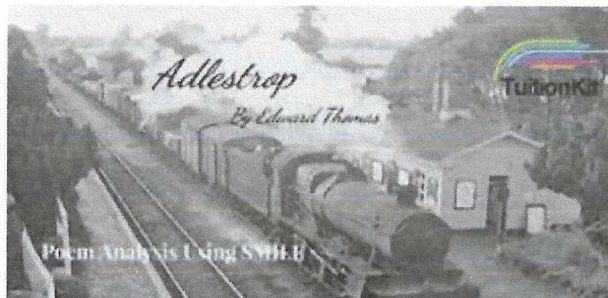
Birds



In 1970 the Swedish national bird, the blackbird, was featured on a 30 öre Christmas postage stamp

The common blackbird's melodious, distinctive song is mentioned in the poem *Adlestrop* by Edward Thomas:

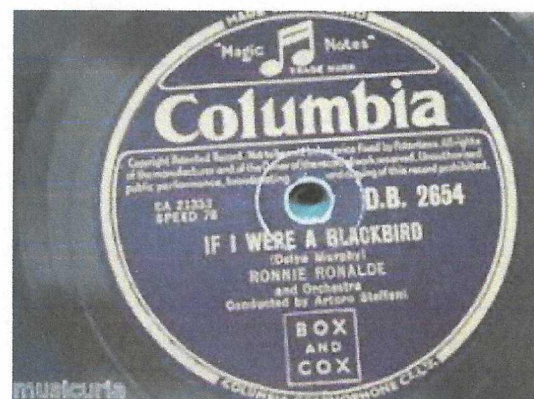
*And for that minute a blackbird sang
Close by, and round him, mistier,
Farther and farther, all the birds
Of Oxfordshire and Gloucestershire*



A blackbird can be heard singing on the Beatles song *Blackbird*

Ronnie Ronald a music hall singer was famous especially in the fifties for his voice, whistling, yodelling and imitations of bird song. Hear him imitating a blackbird in his song

If I were a blackbird, I'd whistle and sing



And don't forget our very own **Blackbird Leys**

Text/facts from RSPB. Lars Jonsson's *Birds of Europe* and Wikipedia

Risinghurst and Sandhills Parish Council ^{August} April 2019

www.risinghurstsandhillsparishcouncil.com

Birds

At least both male and female look after the feeding and the female sometimes leaves the male in charge while she builds another nest!

Sometimes she uses the same nest! They can rear 2 or 3 broods in good conditions.



In gardens, blackbird populations have remained stable, and the number of chicks that fledge per nest is higher than in many other habitats. However, food availability is often a problem, and starvation of chicks is a common occurrence, particularly in dry weather.

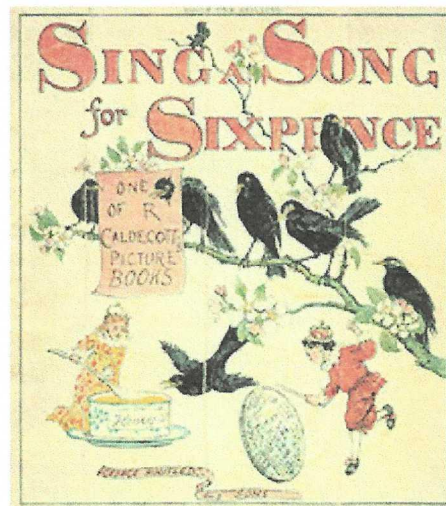


Gardeners can help blackbirds by avoiding the use of garden chemicals, and by planting shrubs that provide blackbirds with worms, snails, caterpillars, and insects, berries, and fruit.

Blackbirds in culture

In the past it was an easily available addition to the diet. In medieval times the practice of placing live birds under a pie crust just before serving may have been the origin of

*Sing a song of sixpence, A pocket full of rye;
Four and twenty blackbirds baked in a pie!
When the pie was opened the birds began to sing,
Wasn't that a dainty dish to set before the king?*



The 4 calling birds may have been 4 colly birds - black as coal birds - a popular English nickname for blackbirds,

Birds

The Blackbird *Turdus Merula*



Familiar to us all,
the male, entirely
black with orange-
yellow bill and eye
ring,
the female dark
brown with slightly
paler brown throat
and breast



Male blackbirds establish a territory during their first year and they will hold this throughout their lives, living to a great extent on the ground often escaping under a bush

They proclaim their territory with their song which you can hear from as early as January and up until July/August when their last brood has fledged.



It's a very recognisable song consisting of a tune with well-articulated flute-like notes and then a gap. There may be 3 or 4 tunes with gaps in between. Then he has a rest before he starts again!

It's something like a boss dictating short phrases so that his secretary has time to write them down.

His alarm call is a series of tongue-clicking *chak* calls ending in a screech as he flies away.



The female not only builds the nest, a substantial cup of grass, straw, small twigs and plastered inside with mud and lined with fine grass, taking up to 2 weeks,



but also incubates the 3-5 eggs on her own,



and it's up to 2 weeks till they hatch, and another 2 weeks to fledge and another to learn to fly.